Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort to make a pretty picture, we often reach for gold when we want to **emphasise something precious**, or when we need **a little celebration**. We do not always know why, though. Sometimes we know exactly, other times not at all. Both are fine.

What may be hiding behind a gold stroke

The same gold line on paper can mean **something completely different every time**, depending on what is going on in us at the moment. That is why there is no point in reading a painting like a test with a single correct answer.

Celebration.

Scattered glittering strokes. Like when a room lights up.

Worth.

A gold frame around something you care about. Emphasis on what you want to protect.

Warmth.

Soft gold areas near the centre. A colour that warms.

The longing for recognition.

A sharp glitter on the edge, often in a visible place. A palm raised in a crowd.

Autumn and farewell.

Gold-green and ochre areas that dissolve. Something is ending and it is beautiful.

Joy in shine.

The pure taste of metal and light. No hidden meaning.

Gold in a painting. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, **it can**, but **it does not have to**. A gold stroke is not automatically a message about vanity or spirituality. It can mean celebration, worth, warmth, the longing for recognition and simple joy in shine. The amount of gold alone does not determine your state. That holds even when a child uses it.

While working you do not have to decide what exactly it means. Notice the hand, the pressure and whether you want to go on. Meaning comes only in connection with **your experience**.

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I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A painting and a dress ask two completely different things of you. Gold in a painting can be warm and beautiful, and still you do not feel like wearing gold jewellery. Or the other way round. A gold frame and gold earrings do not exclude each other.

Imagine the same gold on three women. On a bride, on a singer and on a teenage girl. With the first you say “celebration”, with the second “stage”, with the third “what is she trying to say?”. **The colour has not changed. Your expectations have.**

A golden wardrobe is not automatically a sign of vanity or luxury. First of all it is the wardrobe of a particular woman.

When gold takes over the space

First let the hand work. **Gold does not have to cover anything.** If you are afraid it will ruin everything, try it first on a small paper or hold a gold cut-out against the painting. You will see the change without having to make it permanent right away.

Three things worth noticing

- **SHAPE**

  A line, an area, or glitter?

  A thin gold line can connect or emphasise something. A large area can create warmth as well as ostentation. While working you do not have to decide what exactly it means. Only later can you ask whether the stroke meant celebration, worth or just pleasure in shine.

- **WEIGHT**

  Warming, or loud?

  If the gold feels pleasantly warming, leave it alone for a while and watch its shape. If an area is too loud, open a smaller muted place or add a matt layer. If everything is glossy, add a difference of surface, direction of strokes or lightness.

- **COURAGE**

  You do not have to wrap everything straight away

  Courage in painting does not mean you have to intervene in everything at once. If you want a striking accent, try one line or a small circle. If you keep covering the previous layers, notice the feeling of covering itself. The interpretation can wait.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter how the gold stroke looks. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is happening in your life at that moment. **Two identical paintings can have a completely different meaning.** One came from a feeling of celebration, the other after a day when you wanted to show yourself. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps later you will connect the painting with a period when you felt valued. Perhaps with a decision that gave you strength. Or you will keep seeing in it mainly a beautiful glitter. In self-reflection inspired by art therapy what counts is the connection of the painting, your experience and a specific period of life. Gold by itself does not know your story.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you have painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year, though, it may suddenly dawn on you. That is fine. **The painting will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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